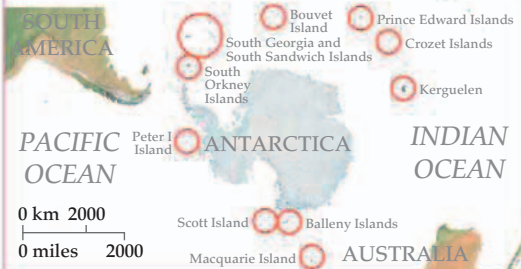


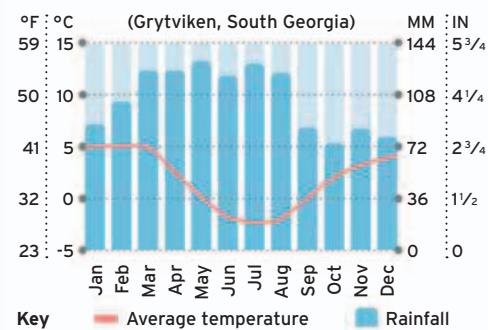
LOCATION

Island groups situated between Antarctica to the south and New Zealand, South Africa, and South America to the north.



CLIMATE

With strong winds and temperatures only slightly above freezing at times, this polar tundra climate has no true summer.



Southern elephant seal

Mirounga leonina

proboscis amplifies mating roars

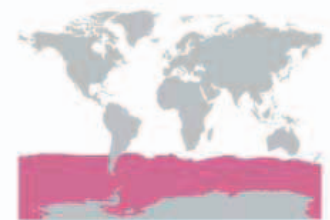


The largest of the pinnipeds, or flipper-footed marine mammals, the southern elephant seal shows the greatest sex-related size difference of all mammals. Males weigh up to 10 times as much as females, and only mature bulls bear the trunklike inflatable proboscis that gives the species its common name.

Fighting to breed

Southern elephant seals may reach depths of up to 6,550 ft (2,000 m) in search of food, aided partly by their special, oxygen-rich red blood cells. They spend up to 90 percent of their lives at sea, often sleeping underwater, but like all seals, they haul out on land to molt, breed, and give birth. Adult males fight for mating rights to groups of females, but only 2–3 percent are successful. The largest harems are controlled by a single dominant bull known as a “beachmaster.” While females and pups can be injured or even killed during these fights, the breeding season is tough on both sexes: males lose an average of 26 lb (12 kg) a day—more than 40 percent of their body weight.

- ↔ 10–16 ft (3–5 m)
- ⬆ Up to 3.3 tons (3 metric tons)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐟 Fish and squid
- 🏠 Home range



Southern Ocean, subantarctic oceans

Southern elephant seals are able to **stay underwater for up to two hours** at a time

▽ DUELING FOR DOMINANCE

Male elephant seals fight for breeding rights early in the mating season. They raise more than half of their body off the ground and inflict wounds to an opponent's neck and face with their teeth.



COLORFUL SWARM
The sea often turns orange-red as vast swarms of Antarctic krill gather in summer. Just 2 in (5 cm) long, krill are shrimplike creatures that feed on phytoplankton (microscopic plants), but they can go up to 200 days without food.

KRILL

